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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Former Advisor at *11x* Believes *AI SDR* Tools Face Challenges and Recommends Niche Focus for Success

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
05 Aug 2025	07 May 2025	Former	Investor-Led (Buy-Side)	11X.AI

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The conversation covers the segmentation of the AI sales tech landscape, the effectiveness of autonomous versus AI-powered SDR tools, and the practical adoption and ROI of various solutions. The expert discusses workflow integration, tool selection, and market outlook for AI-driven sales technologies.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Former strategic advisor to the CEO and go-to-market advisor at a leading AI sales tech company, with 8 years of experience in the sales and marketing tech space and 15 years in SaaS, deeply involved in product and sales meetings for AI-powered sales tools.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Skeptical about the viability and effectiveness of fully autonomous AI SDR solutions, citing high churn and lack of realized value.
- Positive on niche, AI-powered tools that enhance human SDR productivity by automating repetitive tasks, rather than attempting to replace humans entirely.
- Believes the most successful tools will be those that focus on specific pain points, such as data enrichment and account selection, rather than trying to be all-encompassing platforms.

TAKEAWAYS

- The expert distinguishes between 'AI SDR' (autonomous agents) and 'AI-powered SDR' (tools that augment human reps), noting that **the latter is currently far more effective**.
- **Fully autonomous AI SDR solutions have not delivered on their promises, with high customer churn rates** (80-90%) and limited real-world impact, especially in outbound sales where phone calls remain critical.
- Niche tools like Nooks (AI-powered parallel dialer) and **Actively AI (CRM data surfacing) are valued for solving specific workflow inefficiencies** and enabling reps to focus on selling.
- The expert's organization uses a combination of tools for account selection, enrichment, and engagement, with a preference for solutions that streamline repetitive tasks rather than attempt to automate the entire sales process.
- The market for standalone AI-powered sales tools is likely capped at around $100 million in revenue unless companies diversify; large-scale consolidation or acquisition by major players (e.g., Salesforce, Gong) is expected.

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Expert Bio

Strategic Advisor at 11x, leaving Dec 2024. As a former advisor for 11x, the expert knows the industry in great depth. They are also in the evaluation process for their own use. Co-Founder, Chief Revenue Officer at Reachdesk, a customer of Merge. The expert runs everything

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that relates to Sales, Marketing and Partnerships. Reporting to the CEO, the expert has grown Reachdesk from being an unknown player to being a clear market leader. Prior to Reachdesk, the expert was the Sales and Marketing Director at Agillitics, leaving in 2019. The expert launched Agillic's UK office in 2017. The expert also implemented ABM strategy using Direct Mail, Account Based Advertising, Outreach and Digital Content. Worked closely with marketing to align sales and marketing teams internationally.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hi. Thanks for taking the time to talk with me. I am interested in learning more about the AI sales tech space. We just love to hear your background a little bit and your familiarity.

Expert 00:00:11

Sure. I have been in the sales and marketing tech space, my company has been able between the two, for about eight years now. I have been in SaaS for 15 years, but I specifically operated in the sales tech space for eight years. I have been building our company which is predominantly for SDRs. Those are our main users for our business, so many is using it to create and accelerate pipeline. That's my background in terms of my relationship with the space that you guys are in.

I was an advisor to the CEO of 11x for about nine months. I was an advisor to him specifically, mainly, as a firm, but I was also a go-to-market advisor to 11x, and that's where I really learned more about Artisan, Qualified. I already had interactions with Qualified. I have seen their journey and how they have changed from being more of a competitor to Drift to now getting into this AI space.

Looking at the list of what was originally sent to me as well, we also use Nooks and I have been deep in the weeds. I know a lot of the guys like Orum, those kind of tools too. I know that was on your list as well, that was originally sent over. In terms of this space, I have been deep in it. I have been in company meetings, sales meetings, product meetings for tools like 11x, and seeing how those tools have been built.

Client 00:01:31

Cool. Just to level set, how would you think about segmenting the landscape because I feel like there is number in these tools? How would you think about breaking up the names you just mentioned into potentially different categories and what value they're providing?

Expert 00:01:47

Okay. Here's what I say to a lot of people. Maybe the starting point, the big breakout, first and foremost, is I think that companies need to make a decision if they're going after the AI SDR space, let's call it that, or sales tech, agentic, whatever we're calling it. You've either got to be an AI ***SDR*** or an ***AI-powered SDR***, and there's a massive difference between the two.

I used to say this because at ***11x***, the ***AI SDR*** is an autonomous agent. It is something that pretty much does the research, the prospecting, the drafting, sending of emails, replies, that kind of thing. You have an AI SDR, which is more like a Copy.ai, so you're essentially surrounding technology around the human. There's a massive difference between the two.

I'm yet to see a company in the AI SDR space that has built an agent that can operate autonomously and be effective. Yet to see that happen. **I'm seeing way more success with companies** who wrap technology around a human, the AI-powered SDR. That's how I break it out first and foremost.

There's a massive distinction, so lots of **success** seeing companies build amazing workflows around the human outbound rep. I'm yet to see a company that says this all works on its own and is autonomous. If you think about the value proposition there is you don't need SDRs anymore. I don't think that's a possibility right now. I just don't. The main reason being calling.

I have 12 SDRs on my team, they're all humans, and 70% of their meetings get booked over the phone. We use Nooks. Nooks is a really powerful example of that, but maybe we can come back to that a little bit later. That's how I break out first and foremost. Essentially, you've got point solutions, Nooks being a great example. Its main benefit is it helps you dial numerous dials whilst doing the research and surfacing that information to the rep, so they can have a good conversation.

You've got that workflow tools, Copy.ai being an example, there's Triggerfyre, there's n8n. These are tools that do different things. They're more like workflows as opposed to just it enhances a discipline that's already been done, and they can usually do multiple different things. I break it down further in that way. I don't know how much more I want to go. If we're just talking about AI SDRs, I don't think I would break it down any more than that.

Client 00:04:14

That makes sense. You put Qualified, Artisan, ***11x*** in that other bucket of ***AI SDR*** autonomous agents but it's still early.

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Expert 00:04:23

It's still early. I don't know how familiar you guys are with that space.

Client 00:04:28

We see so much marketing and so much talk about these AI SDRs, trying to understand really the value that they provide and how are relative to the AI-powered SDR tools that you mentioned.

Expert 00:04:41

Fine. If it's that level of uncertainty, here's what I saw. Let's use 11x as an example. Companies would get extremely excited because they would think, I've got a team of 10 SDRs, I'm paying each of them if they're in New York, they're getting paid $60,000 base and probably 40%-50% on top. It's like $90,000-$100,000 that I'm paying for one SDR. I've got 10, I'm spending roughly about $1 million a year on a team **that in most cases is underperforming**. Very few companies have figured out how to make outbound work.

In fact, I was at a Pavilion dinner. I'm not sure if you're familiar with Pavilion. It's a revenue community. The entire discussion this morning, this event for two hours, was how to get outbound to work. There's two things there. One is I'm paying a lot of money for these guys. Two, not many companies are actually being successful in getting them to work. Most of the time it's because they don't understand the playbook. They're taking shortcuts, don't understand all the effort that has to go in.

When tools like 11x, Artisan came along, they were essentially saying, "You don't need to pay $1 million anymore, we will build these agents that will do all the work for you. **It saves you** money and we're going to get you better results." That's the value proposition. It's going to cost you 10% and it's going to double your output right now.

Here's what happened when companies started to onboard a tool like that, **it get some benefit** initially up front in the form of accelerated research because these tools can tap your term, your ICP, your messaging, your offers. You put all that in, you essentially build a prompt, and then that goes and finds all the accounts, does the research and then starts drafting the messages.

You would essentially get this fake value upfront really because it's basically saying all of that effort that typically takes an SDR between 30%-40% of their time, that activity that they're doing, they don't need to do it anymore. **The problem** is, when the rubber hit the road, certain things were happening.

You've got to remember these agents cannot call. They can't dial the emails that they're sending. They're still emails. A lot of them go into junk, very low response rates. They weren't having a massive impact. A lot of them were hallucinating. They were giving offers that shouldn't be and that's very common in this market.

Ultimately, even if you were reaching those buyers, you've gone after all those accounts. You've now burnt through a ton of your TAM. **You've done a lot of damage to your email domains**, even if you've got multi domains running in the background. You've either sent the wrong message or if it has landed, it hasn't fully landed because a lot of them are going into inboxes which are getting deleted. The value proposition **it's been a bit false** so far because you're not actually doing what it says on the tin, which I'm going to double your output.

Yes, you're going after those accounts and you're doing a lot of research, but the actual communication is the single thing **that is failing** the most because it's not multichannel, it's mainly email. It's either not been part of a warmed up domain so **it's going in the wrong place**. You're burning through a lot of it very quickly, and as a result, you're not seeing a lot of value, so **it was massive churn**.

Client 00:08:09

Yeah. I'm going to ask a question there. When you use AI SDR, what exactly are you using it for? We want to understand, are you using it on everything that you talk about, like getting accelerated research, building ICT profile, drafting messages, or are you just using it for that research aspect? Basically, I want to understand what workflow are you currently using AI SDR for? In terms of inbound versus outbound too, how you would think about segmenting the workflows based on that? They're covering both ends of the spectrum or focusing on a specific area?

Expert 00:08:44

We only use an AI agent, let's call it, for instances where we don't think calling is necessary. We don't think qualification needs to happen. It's essentially happening in instances like, I think we've got four examples, a big one being when we attend an event. We attend an event, someone scans a badge or we've got a list or something, we can put context in, so we can put notes in Salesforce.

Let's say the AE at the event meets someone, they put a note in that will then be translated into an email and sent as an immediate follow-up with an action to book a meeting. It's just basically saving time because it's common that **it's very painful** for teams to have to follow up, essentially, quickly after events, they leave it for weeks.

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The point is it's been too long, forgotten who you are, doesn't work. We use it for instance like that, webinar, follow-ups. We do use it for some inbound instances. If someone goes onto the website, clicks on our demo page but doesn't actually book a meeting. We actually know who they are a lot of the time. We use things like 6sense. We can then get them to get the AI agent to then actually email those guys or connect with them on LinkedIn to try and get them over the line. Those are good use cases. I think that they actually work for us. They book meetings with high quality opportunities that you end up going on to close.

My advice to these businesses, particularly 11x, was stop selling this concept that you've got this outbound rep that's going to research, it's going to personalize, it's going to essentially have this multichannel approach. From a cold standpoint, that's where it really doesn't work.

There are about six or seven different use cases that we did come up with. **The problem** was all the customers wanted outbound reps. They didn't want to use it for the low hanging fruit, which they probably thought they could automate themselves anyway. They wanted it to be like, "No, we're having problems with the research aspect. We want to go after new markets for example." They wanted to use it for cold prospecting because that's when 90% of businesses have put their SDRs.

Historically, it hasn't been for the low hanging fruit. That's just workflows that you can typically automate. It's been go and get me a new revenue stream, a new channel, **which has been more like cold outbound**. That's what these companies are essentially positioning themselves. Again, that's what customers want. Every single customer, when they were jumping on, on boarding calls, they're like, "Yeah, fine about the event stuff, love it, but I want you to go and raid my ICP."

Client 00:11:17

They couldn't do that yet?

Expert 00:11:19

No, because cold doesn't work very effectively. You've got to warm them up. It's a long game. It takes 28-30 touch points on average. Since you're knocking on a door where you're going to get low responses anyway, if you're cutting out the critical channel, which is the phone, **you're at a disadvantage**, you're not at an advantage.

Client 00:11:39

Got it. Actually, take a step back. We've also seen sales start-ups that are helping BDRs to identify leads better, like Actively AI. In your opinion, are **these people better** positioned to build out an AI SDR than companies like Nooks or Qualified?

Expert 00:11:55

I wouldn't put Nooks in the same category as Qualified. I'd put Nooks in its own. I don't know how they're positioning themselves now, maybe they've changed it. They call themselves an AI sales assistant platform. They're jumping on the bandwagon ultimately. Look, Nooks is really good at parallel dialing, dialing 10, 20 numbers at the same time. The right person picks up, it says, "This person's picked up. Here's what you say to them," and you can essentially 10X your outreach. We've seen massive results from that.

You mentioned Actively there. I think Actively is a really good example. Again, let's level set. My opinion on this market is I don't think anyone should be calling any of these AI SDR. I just don't think that is ever going to exist. I can't see how it's going to happen. I think the companies **that are going to succeed** are the ones that are going to pick really niche use cases.

I love Actively AI's use case. We're about to pilot them actually because what it does is **it essentially solves the problem** of where all that data in my CRM, people have to sift through. Humans have to sift through to find good accounts to then surface all those interactions to then prioritize which ones we go after. I've calculated. That takes up at least 20% of my reps' time. That's a massive inefficiency.

That's not just SDRs, that's account executives as well. I have a team of 25, across all of them, they're spending at least 20% of their time wasted doing that activity. Actually, actively value proposition which I really like is "We're not going to remove the human. We're going to enable the human, and we're going to surface data that they already need in a more intelligent fashion, and we're going to essentially surface that information to them, so they can either one, focus those sales efforts elsewhere and do more selling, or two, just get them better information which is going to give them a better chance of succeeding."

That is the equivalent to that first bucket I gave you earlier, which is are you going to be the AI SDR, the AI-powered SDR and this is powering the human to do better work. It's a really niche use case. I like those kind of companies. I buy into the value that they're going to deliver. It's very believable. I think **it's a really good niche** and they're not trying to do this top to bottom approach, which is what the AI SDR companies doing is like, "We're going to try doing everything. We do all of it for you and we're going to do all of the outreach." One, I think it's too much. I just don't buy into it. I like these really niche point solutions that are fixing specific problems.

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Client 00:14:34

Yeah. Some of these supposedly autonomous AI SDRs like Qualified, 11x, Artisan, **they seem to have really strong growth** based anecdotally on what we've heard, is there is real traction from a revenue perspective. Do you view that as just hype though? Have they been able to market this product and this dream of fully automating SDR and firing 90% of your team. Has there been real ROI in your perspective from those investments? Do you think these customers will ultimately just churn or there's real value to be created there?

Expert 00:15:07

I can tell you I'm probably one of the few people in the world that can confirm this, the value is not there. The churn is monumental. **It's the worst** I've seen out of any category. I'm an advisor to about five different sales tech companies. **The AI SDR category has the worst churn out of anything** I've ever seen in the 80%-90% churn.

I remember someone coming to me knowing that I was an advisor here, I'm no longer an advisor there by the way, but someone said, they called me up and they said, "The sales pitch blew my mind." The sales pitch is one of the best pitches I've ever seen because what I told you earlier, those 10 reps are costing me $1 million.

I'm being told that I can double the output. It just wasn't realized. The value was not realized. Because all these companies are doing three month pilots, at the three month mark, they're going, "This is not what we signed up for at all. We're not seeing any value." There's immense churn going on there. The growth is all talk.

Client 00:16:12

Got it. Can you walk us through why you picked Nooks out of all these AI SDR tools? What's the reason that you still stick with Nooks?

Expert 00:16:20

We looked at Orum, we looked at Nooks, we looked at, what they called, ConnectAndSell. Essentially, I will be very honest with you, I hired a director of BDR who came in, actually I've known him for a long time and he came in, he said, '**Dude, the biggest gap** we have got is we don't have a power dialer." I was really skeptical to be honest with you.

I said, "I'm not a fan. I don't know how you can have a personalized, relevant conversation. If you are calling 20-30 people at the same time, first, you do not know who is going to pick up, and when you do, how are you going to know what to say?" He was like, "Let us make that part of the decision criteria. We need to make sure that reps can essentially do more activity whilst not sacrificing on quality."

We didn't see that in ConnectAndSell. It was very close between them and Orum, but ultimately Nooks allowed us to do a trial. They said the trials are for three months. I'm not even sure we paid for it. We saw massive results, and I said, "I don't want to see massive results and then a massive drop. I need to make sure we have got enough time." It puts three months to trial it.

We saw consistently great results because what happened was the phone channel, particularly, in the U.S., now 80% of our revenue is in the U.S. by the way, most of our customers are in the States, and it has become harder and harder to engage with those prospects because of how all your phone systems and everything work over there and you can block calls very easily.

A month after we put Nooks on, **we had the best quarter in terms of outbound pipeline** we have ever achieved in the history of our company. We were like, "Wow. Okay, now I'm sold." I said, "Look, hands in the air. I was very skeptical but you have convinced me." The reason why I love Nooks, it doesn't sacrifice that quality because it prompts the rep on what to say. We can hit more people. In fact, I did do this, I ended up reducing my BDR team down slightly because with fewer heads, after we put Nooks in, we were getting much better productivity in terms of output. **It's one of the best things** we did.

That is the example of a really specific use case around enabling the rep to do more without sacrificing quality with this very specific use case and not trying to do everything within the outbound process. They said, "We're going to do the research. We're going to find accounts and we're going to call them, we're going to email." I'd be like, "What are you actually good at, guys?" They are really good at that.

Client 00:18:57

How did they do that? What did they do to prompt reps on what you say?

Expert 00:19:01

I think from my understanding, what happens is when it connects, a little pop-up appears and it essentially gives you a prompt. I think that had to be built with a lot of our internal ops teams so that we enrich data on the contact with their title, and that kind of thing triggers previous interactions that they might have gone close lost, and so **we're now reviving them**. A little, essentially, sidebar appears and it gives you a prompt on what to say.

Let's say you're my prospect. I say, "Hey, how have you been?" is the first question we ask. That essentially gives the rep a little bit of time

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to get their bearings on the prompt because they don't really know who they actually speaking to until they've really read it because it's parallel dialing, it's calling 20 people at the same time.

Once they've got the grips of that they say, "Look, the reason why I'm calling is because," and then Nooks is giving you the prompt. It's not necessarily scripting, it's just giving you the bullets on what to say. We've trained our team to be able to interpret that data very quickly to have a meaningful conversation.

Client 00:20:03
To level set, how big is your company? What size customer do you represent for Nooks? I'm trying to understand if they're selling into large enterprises.

Expert 00:20:12
We're Series B. We did $43 million Series B. My go-to-market team is a team of about 40 people in total. We're not a huge company, but I know they're selling to much smaller customers too. We're probably somewhere in the middle.

Client 00:20:26
Got it. That's the question too. These theoretically could be tailored for anywhere from SMB to enterprise. The value prop remains true across the spectrum of scale?

Expert 00:20:38
Yeah, I think so.

Client 00:20:39
Okay. Do you know where is Nooks getting the information to generate these prompts? Are they connected to data sources and getting information from past customer interactions? I'm just trying to understand, are they grabbing it from company internal database or external?

Expert 00:20:54
I don't think they're getting externals right now. We have ZoomInfo for the U.S. We have Cognizant for the U.K. market. We still do have to do the work upfront. Nooks even saying, "We've generated a list of people for you guys to call. Ourselves, we've selected the accounts we want to call already. We've enriched them with those prospects and the data on their titles," and that kind of thing. Their company data is in that database.

Nooks is just facilitating the AI dialer of automating those call tasks to increase the volume, the connect, for conversions. I think they are doing number enrichment and that kind of thing. They're not saying, "We found these 10 accounts for you. Here are the people. We've enriched all of it for you," all that stuff. That's not what they're doing. Their bread-and-butter is on that dialing assistant. They're not doing the data research. They're not doing that heavy lifting there.

Client 00:21:46
Are there any other tools in that AI-powered sales SDR set that you find interesting? I know you mentioned obviously Nooks and Actively AI both are compelling. Are you guys using any other tools or thinking about trialing anything else?

Expert 00:22:01
What's the ones on the list at the moment? Is it Ocean AI? That's more like data enrichment. Ocean.io maybe. We were talking about this earlier. Essentially finding lookalikes for ideal accounts and contacts. We use 6sense Conversation Intelligence. It's like our AI agent. That's the email thing I was describing earlier. We're using Nooks. I think Clay is probably a big one for data enrichment. They're probably one of the pioneers at the moment. Who else? There's Goodfit.io.

One of our big problems at the moment is the account selection and account enrichment, which is why we're looking at Actively AI and Ocean. We use Salesloft as our outbound sequencing tool. I think those tools have had its day. Let me find the one that we're actually looking at replacing Salesloft with because that would be a huge move. I think it was Unify. I think they're really interesting because they're aggregating signals. They're taking things like intent, data signals, website signals, and they're building workflows, like account qualification. I think they look quite interesting to us in terms of what we might be thinking about replacing a Salesloft with.

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Client 00:23:14

Yeah. Actually, I was wondering, so you have a lot of different tools here, can you quickly walk us through an SDR workflow? At what stage do they engage with which tool?

Expert 00:23:25

Let's get in the workflow. Account selection, this is probably the thing that most companies find the hardest is how do I get the right accounts constantly refreshed and in the right rep's hands. That is a workflow thing in and of itself. That's usually going to be operated by a RevOps team. What they're essentially doing is saying that based on website visit, intent, data signals, lists, cold, closed, lots of different variables.

Although that data needs to be crunched, it needs to be scored and then prioritized so that you can then say these are your accounts right now. Ideally for the week, much bigger companies will have a territory that's going away. They're trying to get a smaller amount of accounts that have been really well-scored in terms of intent and good fit to be able to say these are your accounts.

A lot of companies, they do still spend a lot of time sifting through Salesforce, CRM, that kind of thing, trying to find accounts. That's phase one account selection, then it's account enrichment and contact enrichment. This is why tools like Clay are having a field day at the moment because reps would typically have to go into somewhere like ZoomInfo, get the account, find all the five or six people they've got to prospect, enrich them, do research on them on an individual level, so look at their LinkedIn, that kind of thing, as well as what's going on in the company, so if it's public listed. You look into earnings reports, those kind of things.

Also, they have to literally get the data, put it into the contact, enrich it before they can even start prospecting. That step two is the data enrichment, then they have to start doing things like calling, emailing, social selling, messaging on LinkedIn, doing things like connection requests. That's when the sales motion starts happening.

Those are the three core stages that have to be achieved, and all of them take a lot of time, almost the equal amount of time in terms of time spent and often wasted by reps to be able to accomplish the task. The account selection piece, you've got tools like Ocean, Goodfit, I would put Actively in there as well. You've also got incumbent solutions like ZoomInfo who do help with the cancellation side of things.

In terms of enrichment, you've got Clay, you've got FullEnrich, you've got Cognizant, you've got ZoomInfo. Clay and FullEnrich are two of the newer ones. There's one called, what do we call it, we're about to start using it quite soon, Prospect, which is another AI-powered data-enrichment service. You've got one called Salesmotion which does tells you everything you need to know about the account, so Salesmotion.io. Those are probably some of the biggest ones I know there.

In terms of the actual engagement type of thing, this is where it really opens up. This is where the Nooks, the Orums come into play, you've got your AI SDRs like Artisan, 11x. You've got obviously what they called Lavender, like email personalization tools. You've got phone, which is the dial, you've got the email side of things, you've got the data enrichment side things. Unify, obviously being another one. Yeah, I bucket them more quite quickly into those three categories.

Client 00:26:37

You would put Unify under the last bucket?

Expert 00:26:40

Yeah. I would put them under the last bit because I think they are more about the engagement side of things. Although they would sit perhaps they would sit across that bit and that second bucket quite a few.

Client 00:26:51

Do you think for tools like Unify that stood across these buckets have the potential to aggregate all of these point solutions together?

Expert 00:27:00

Perhaps. I can't name many B2B tech companies that have been fantastic at multiple different things. Pretty much all of them that I've seen that have tried have failed along the way. I'm including tools like Gong in that. They're really good at the conversation intelligence side of things. **They went to forecasting, not very good at forecasting**. They went into cadencing, **it's not very good**.

Very few companies have mastered the art of being able to be good at these things. I think it's just because it's very different disciplines. Parallel dialing on a phone line is wildly different from enriching accounts. It's different infrastructure, it's different knowledge. I think they'd struggle. I think companies need to focus and be great at a few things rather than being the master to everyone.

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Client 00:27:48

That being said though, do you think there's a big enough market for Nooks in AI-powered dialing to become a $1-billion company, or is it they get $1 billion of revenue? Do they get acquired by Salesforce or Gong? There feels like there's so many tools **that have exploded in the past couple of years**.

What does the next three to five years look like? Do these just the best ones continue to grow and then ultimately get acquired by Salesforce, Gong, Clari? Is there going to just be massive consolidation, or do you think there's real legs and room to play as standalone tools in the space because they're creating a category?

Expert 00:28:26

Yeah. It's a very good question. How many B2B tech companies in this space who are doing $1 billion in revenue? ZoomInfo is probably one of the few I can name. If we're trying to get into $100 million in revenue and then a 10X valuation at $1 billion, that's a very different game. Which one are we talking about?

Client 00:28:48

I think revenue because I think a number of these companies are at $100 million of revenue or will be able to get there per se. Is there room beyond that almost? Maybe not $1 billion of revenue, maybe that's not as realistic. I'm just curious, how big is the market? Do they run into each other at that $100 million mark or something? Is Nooks really have such a differentiated product and a moat and a big enough TAM that **they could be a multi-billion dollar company and just really keep growing**? I don't know, I'm trying to understand because the industry is so new.

Expert 00:29:23

I can't see companies like Nooks getting to $500 million in revenue just from doing what they're doing. **They would unfortunately** have to diversify. It depends what we're already asking. Would they diversify and be really good at all those things? Probably not, but could they? They could go down the route of enriching contact data, account scoring, lead list building. That's suddenly a much bigger company.

I don't think Nooks is going to get past $100 million in revenue by doing what they're doing today. I know they are selling things like role playing and that sort of thing. I don't think that's a massive market, to be honest with you. I think they could probably get to $100 million with what they've got. I don't think they could get further than that. I do think Salesforce, probably the likes of Gong maybe are going to be the guys who are going to be buying some of these guys up.

I'm yet to see something that I think, "Wow, this is the next." I always use ZoomInfo as the example. They are the ones that did IPO. They are probably about that in revenue. I'm yet to see someone even come close to what they did. As a reminder of what ZoomInfo had to do, had to acquire probably 10 companies along the way to get there. They did not build it from just a database. They made numerous acquisitions to make that happen. That's probably the route to make this work.

I'm yet to see anyone come close to that. Gong's probably been one of the closest. Maybe Salesloft was the other one. Obviously they got acquired, what was it, by Vista for $2.5 billion. They were at nine figures in revenue and they were the closest. I can't see anyone getting beyond that in terms of who I'm seeing in the market at the moment.

Client 00:31:09

That's super helpful. Another question that we had is, can Qualified or Artisan do what Nooks is doing?

Expert 00:31:16

It probably could. When I was working with the guys at 11x, they built a dialing agent. Essentially, that's more of a speed to lead use case. There's nothing stopping Qualified, Unify from building a parallel dialer. I don't think it would be too hard. They could build it quite easily.

Client 00:31:36

How much are you spending on Nooks?

Expert 00:31:37

We spend I think less than $50,000 a year. That is for 10 reps. We did get a very good deal.

Client 00:31:45

Got it. Just to clarify, when we were talking about Artisan, Qualified, 11x, currently they don't have a dialing agent?

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Expert 00:31:53

They don't have what Nooks has. They don't have an agent that can dial 10, 20 people at the same time. Once they connect, route it to a sales rep. What I know 11x can do is they can call people back and have a conversation, so I might leave my number, it would call me back because you have to have permission to robocall. The difference here is it's a robot, it's an agent, it is autonomous talking to you. It's probably the actual thing that really worked for them. There's a distinction here.

Nooks is saying, "We called 20 people. This person's on the line now. Have a conversation with them." 11x is, I think they call it Jordan, but I think they've changed it now. I can't remember what they call it. That agent, it will call me back. I might have made an inquiry. It's having a conversation with you essentially to qualify whether you're a good fit or not so that you can then pass it on to someone. That is more like B2C use case.

They were using it for, I remember one big example was, what were they doing, it was a law firm where they had to dial 10,000 people at the same time to get certain information out of them. They're not prospecting them. These guys have opted into a database.

Client 00:33:12

Anything else that we didn't ask that you think we should look into further as we do more work on the sales tech space, like relevant trends, particularly pain points that you think sales teams are facing that could be addressed with a tool like these, I don't know, other things that we should potentially be on the look out for?

Expert 00:33:30

I don't think there's anything in addition, for example. My perspective on this space is very simple. The people that are going to win are the ones that are essentially giving massive efficiency by eliminating those mundane, repeatable tasks that are actually very easy to replicate by human but ultimately take a lot of time.

The ones **that are getting it wrong** are the ones that are trying to completely replace the human. I'm just not seeing it work. I speak to CRO and RevOps leader after RevOps leader saying, "We were promised that we didn't need this, and we could replace our humans entirely." We were massively disappointed. I think it comes around the point of interaction. The moment you have to speak to someone, the moment you have to deliver something that should be highly personalized is where these companies are failing.

If it were me, I would be betting more on the tools that are doing those things, like helping me find accounts, enriching data, because it takes so much time and it's a pain to everyone. If you've got an outbound team, those are things **that take probably the most time and the most painful exercises**. If you can eliminate those, you are essentially helping them focus on just selling. That's why I think those people are going to win. That's why I think **tools like Clay are winning at the moment** because they've chosen that area, not so much the communication part.

Client 00:34:52

Okay. Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. Have a nice day.

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